TEAM LEADER ESSENTIALS

Team Leader Essentials — Day 5: Motivating, Recognizing, and Building Trust

Study guide · Self-study

Day 5: Motivating, Recognizing, and Building Trust

How to Use This Guide

This is Day 5 of Team Leader Essentials, the last day of the course. You work through it alone. Read a section, do the short exercise where one appears, then write your answers in the "What Would You Say?" section before you look at the model answers at the end.

The guide builds on what you already covered on Day 1 through Day 4. You heard then that your job changed from producing results yourself to being accountable for the team's results. You learned to set clear expectations and run a daily huddle, to coach with questions rather than instructions, and to handle underperformance and conflict early. Today you turn to something that decides whether all of that effort lasts: whether your team members feel motivated to keep giving you their best, and whether they trust you enough to tell you the truth when things go wrong.

You do not need to bring results, data or a large team to do this. You need your real team members, your real memory of the last few weeks, and a willingness to look at your own behavior honestly. Keep a notebook open. Write as you go.

Today's Objectives (KASU)

Knowledge: You will know what research says about specific goals, including their strengths and their risks, and why different team members are moved by different things.

Attitude: You will treat recognition as a planned leadership behavior, not a reward you hand out when you happen to notice something, and accept that trust is built mainly by your consistency and fairness.

Skill: You will be able to design a recognition approach for each team member and run a short conversation that connects their work to something that matters to them.

Upskill: You will write your own personal leadership development goal in the four-part KASU structure, so you can use it again for future goals long after this course ends.

Goals: What They Help and What They Hurt

Specific, challenging goals, paired with feedback, tend to produce higher performance than vague instructions to do your best. That finding comes from a large body of research summarized by Locke and Latham. It explains why your Day 2 work on clear expectations mattered: when team members know exactly what good looks like and get regular feedback, they aim higher.

But goals have a shadow side. Ordóñez and colleagues argued that narrow or overly aggressive goals can push people toward shortcuts, extra risk-taking and sometimes behavior they would not choose without the target pressing on them. A team member chasing a call volume number may rush calls. Someone chasing a sales total may oversell to a customer who will regret the purchase.

Both findings are true at the same time. That is why you watch how a goal is met, not just whether it is met. When you review results, ask how the number was reached. Praise the method as well as the outcome. A team that hears you ask "how did you get there?" learns that the way matters.

This connects to motivation in a practical way. A target answers "what do I need to hit?" It never answers "why does it matter to me?" Recognition, done well, answers that second question. And that is where most leaders leave value on the table.

What Actually Motivates People

People are not moved by one single thing. One team member wants to develop skills for a bigger role. Another wants stability and a predictable schedule. Another wants to be respected by peers as the person who solves hard problems. Another wants autonomy: to be trusted to decide how the work gets done.

Your job is not to guess what motivates everybody, but to find out what motivates each person. The most reliable way is to ask, and then to listen. Try a simple question in your next one-on-one: "What part of your work last month felt most worth the effort?" The answer tells you more about someone's motivation than any personality label.

A second useful idea is that small, real things beat large, rare ones. A note the same week saying specifically what someone did well lands harder than a grand gesture months later that nobody connects to a moment. Why? Because people remember what is close in time and specific in detail. Vague praise fades into background noise; precise praise sticks because the person can recognize themselves in it.

This is why a shared "employee of the month" scheme so often disappoints. It is rare, generic, and chosen by someone else's criteria. Specific recognition, given close to the event and tied to the person's own goals, does the work instead.

Recognition That Feels Real

Recognition fails when it feels automatic or invented. Most people can tell the difference between praise you had to give and praise you wanted to give. If your feedback sounds like a template, they hear the template.

Make recognition specific, timely and connected to impact. Use what you learned about SBI on Day 2 as a reminder: name the situation, the behavior and the impact. "In yesterday's customer call, you stayed calm when the customer was frustrated, and they renewed on the spot. That protected the relationship." That sentence works because the person can see exactly what you saw.

Match the form of recognition to the person. Some team members love being named in front of the group. Others find it uncomfortable and would rather hear it privately. Some value written notes they can keep. Some value time and attention: twenty minutes of your full focus on their development question. Ask each person what kind of recognition they prefer, and write down the answer.

Watch one common mistake: recognizing the same top performers over and over while the steady middle of your team hears nothing. The quiet people who do reliable work are easy to overlook because they create no problems. They also notice the silence. Make a list of everyone and check that each name has had real recognition in the recent past.

The Psychology of Trust

Trust is not a speech. It is a prediction people make about you based on your track record. Every time you keep a small promise, arrive when you said you would, follow up when you said you would, and treat people the same way on a hard day as on an easy one, you add to that prediction.

Three behaviors carry most of the weight:

Consistency. The same rule applies to everyone, including the people you like best. Favoritism, even small, is spotted quickly and poisons everything else you say.

Fairness under pressure. How you behave when a customer is angry or a target is missed tells your team what you really value. If you throw someone under the bus in front of a customer, they will never fully trust you again.

Vulnerability. Saying "I got that wrong, here is what I'll do differently" does not weaken your authority. It signals that mistakes can be admitted, which is exactly what you need if you want early warning about problems. Teams whose leaders admit error surface issues sooner.

There is a useful test for yourself: would a team member tell you about a mistake they made before you found out? If the answer is no, trust is thin, and the fix starts with your reaction the next time someone brings you bad news. Thank them for it, plainly.

Set Your Own Development Goal with KASU

You first met KASU on Day 1 as a way to structure learning objectives. Use it now for yourself. Set one leadership development goal for the next three months, with all four parts.

Knowledge: what you need to learn. For example: what motivates each of my team members and how each prefers to be recognized.

Attitude: the mindset you are shifting toward. For example: recognition is a scheduled part of my week, not an occasional extra.

Skill: what you will be able to do. For example: hold a short recognition conversation with each team member at least once a month.

Upskill: the advanced application. For example: teach the recognition practice to a peer leader so it spreads beyond my team.

Write your own version in the exercise below. Keep it to one goal. A single specific goal you actually pursue beats five you forget.

> **NOTES**
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> The most common mistake here is writing an Upskill line that is just a bigger version of the Skill line. Upskill should stretch you beyond your own team, such as teaching, mentoring or applying the skill in a harder context.

Apply It in Your Role

Take ten minutes with your team list and do these three things.

First, for each person, write one sentence on what they seem to care about most at work. If you cannot fill a line, that is your first conversation this week.

Second, note the last time you gave each person specific recognition. If any name is blank or shows a date you are embarrassed by, that person gets your attention first.

Third, look at your own trust behaviors from the past week. Did you keep every small commitment? Did anyone see you treat two people differently for no clear reason? Write the one behavior you will correct first.

If you lead a customer service or sales team with a mixed group, remember that the same principles hold whether the work is handled on the phone, in person or with business customers. What changes is the detail in your recognition, not the idea.

What Would You Say?

Read each situation and write your answer in your own words before looking at the model answers. These are examples, not scripts. Write in two or three sentences.

Situation 1: A team member, years in the role, has started doing the minimum. They used to be reliable and engaged. When you ask how things are going, they say "fine" and nothing else.

Your answer: _____

Situation 2: You want to recognize a team member who quietly keeps every customer happy but never tops any results list.

Your answer: _____

Situation 3: A team member made a mistake and told you before you found out. The mistake cost the team some time.

Your answer: _____

Situation 4: You notice yourself giving more praise to the people you enjoy working with.

Your answer: _____

> **NOTES**
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> Write before you check. If your answer sounds nothing like you, rewrite it as you would actually say it.

Key Takeaways

- Specific, challenging goals with feedback tend to lift performance, but narrow or aggressive goals can push people toward shortcuts, so watch how results are reached.
- Different team members are moved by different things; find out by asking and listening, not by guessing.

- Recognition works when it is specific, timely and connected to the person's own goals and their preferred way of receiving it.
- The quiet reliable people are the easiest to overlook; check your team list regularly so no one hears silence.
- Trust comes from consistency, fairness under pressure and the willingness to admit your own mistakes.
- Your own development deserves the same structure you give your team: write one goal using Knowledge, Attitude, Skill and Upskill.

Quiz

Answer each question, then check the answer key in the notes.

1. A team member hits a stretch sales target. What does the research summary in this guide suggest you should check?

   A. Only the number, since results are what count

   B. Whether the target was set to a round figure

   C. How the result was reached, including any shortcuts taken

   D. Whether the customer liked the team member

2. Why does specific, timely recognition land better than a rare, generic award?

   A. Because people can recognize themselves in the detail and it is close in time

   B. Because awards cost more money

   C. Because team members prefer ceremonies

   D. Because generic praise is always dishonest

3. A team member tells you about a costly mistake before you discover it. What is the best response for building trust?

   A. Speak to them privately about the cost of the error first, then thank them after a few days

   B. Thank them for coming forward, then address the mistake itself

   C. Copy the whole team on the error as a lesson

   D. Ignore it, so they feel supported

4. Your recognition has started to go mostly to the same two people. What should you do?

   A. Accept it; they earn it

   B. Stop recognizing anyone for a while

   C. Work from your full team list and make sure each name gets real, specific recognition

   D. Ask the two people to share the credit

5. Which of these is a well-formed Upskill line for your own KASU development goal?

   A. Learn what motivates each team member

   B. Hold a recognition conversation with each team member monthly

   C. Treat recognition as a scheduled part of my week

D. Teach the recognition practice to a peer team leader

Upskill Challenge

In the two weeks after this course, complete these on the job.

☐ Hold one short conversation with each team member asking what kind of recognition they prefer.

☐ Deliver at least one act of specific recognition to each person, in the form they told you they prefer.

☐ Write your KASU development goal in full, one line per part: Knowledge, Attitude, Skill and Upskill.

☐ Pick the one trust behavior you will correct first and note it where you will see it daily.

☐ At the end of the week, review: did every name on your team get real recognition, and did your behavior stay consistent?

If you do not lead a team yet, do the recognition steps with three colleagues you work closely with.

Personal leadership development goal

Knowledge: ____

Attitude: ____

Skill: ____

Upskill: ____

Model Answers

These are examples, not scripts. What matters is the principle behind each one.

Situation 1: "You've been here a long time and you used to really enjoy this work. Lately it seems like something has changed. Can you tell me what would make your work feel worth the effort again?" Why it works: it names the change without accusing, and invites the person to say what they actually need. A disengaged long-serving team member often feels unseen rather than unmotivated.

Situation 2: "The way you handle customers, nothing ever escalates and they keep coming back. That steady reliability is exactly what keeps our reputation strong. I want you to know I see it." Why it works: it is specific, it names the impact, and it is true. It also tells the person that quiet reliability is valued, not invisible.

Situation 3: "Thank you for telling me before I found out. That is exactly the behavior I want on this team. Now let's look at what happened and how we fix it." Why it works: thanking first rewards honesty, and separating the honesty from the mistake keeps the trust you need for early warning.

Situation 4: "I've noticed I've been praising the same people more often, and that isn't fair. I'm going to work through the whole team list, starting this week." Why it works: fairness is built on behavior people can see. Admitting the bias out loud and correcting it openly signals consistency.

- Quiz answers:

- 1. C. Specific goals raise performance, but narrow or aggressive ones can push people toward shortcuts, so the method matters.
- 2. A. Specific detail close in time lets the person see exactly what was noticed; general praise that arrives long after the event fades.
- 3. B. Thanking first shows a mistake can be admitted; then you address the error itself.
- 4. C. Quiet, reliable members are easy to overlook; a full list makes the gaps visible.
- 5. D. Upskill stretches beyond your own team; the other options are Knowledge, Skill and Attitude lines.

References

- Locke, E. A., & Latham, G. P. (2002). Building a practically useful theory of goal setting and task motivation: A 35-year odyssey. American Psychologist, 57(9), 705–717.
- Ordóñez, L. D., Schweitzer, M. E., Galinsky, A. D., & Bazerman, M. H. (2009). Goals gone wild: The systematic side effects of overprescribing goal setting. Academy of Management Perspectives, 23(1), 6–16.